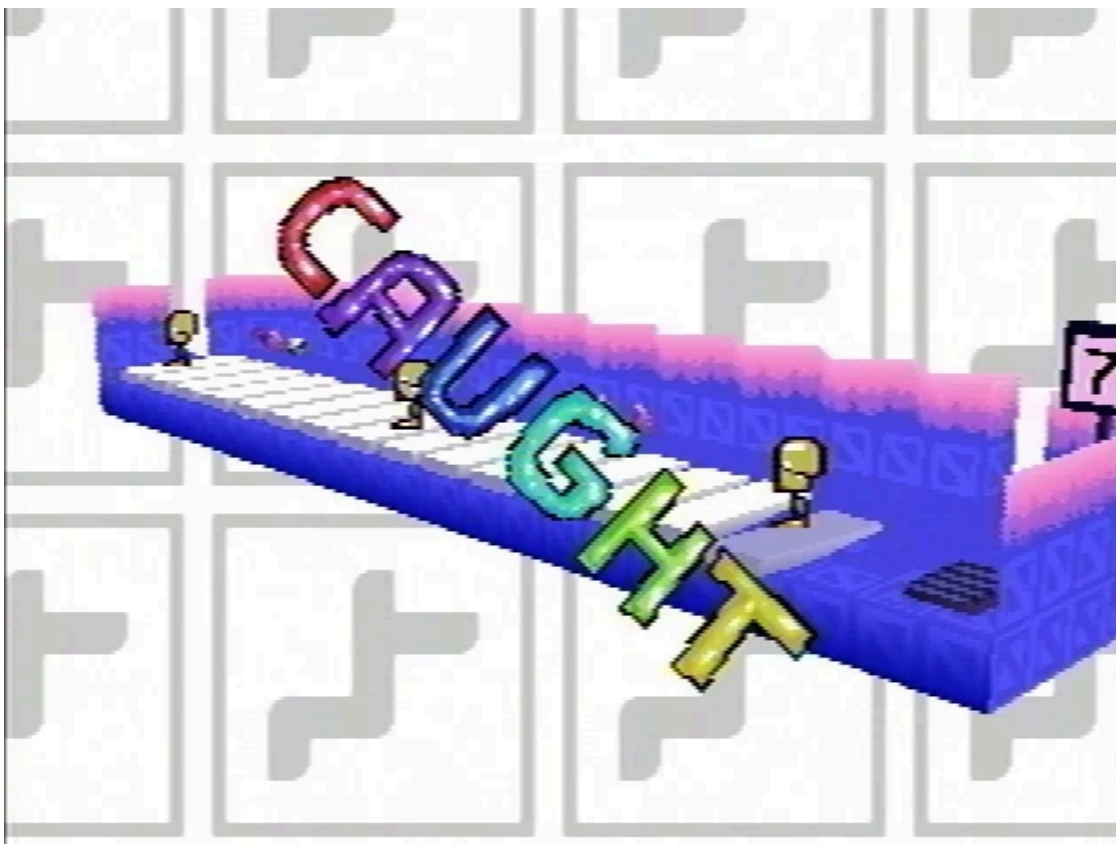


A creepypasta myth is being born around a supposedly unreleased 1997 game

By [Randall Colburn \(/author/randallcolburn\)](#) | April 24, 2017 | 6:28pm

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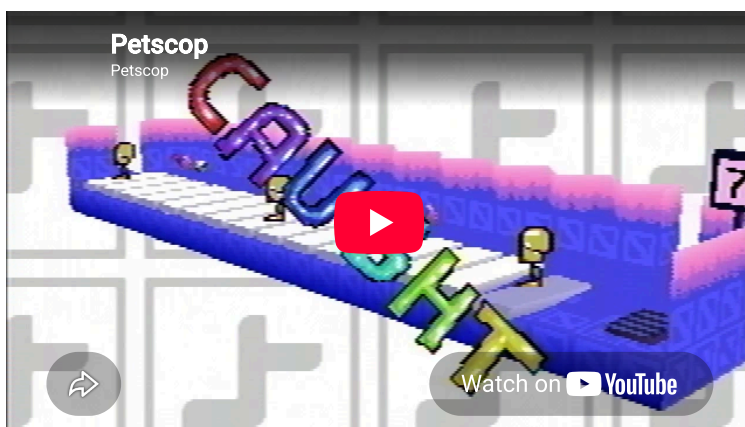
[Creepypastas \(/https://www.avclub.com/article/new-study-breaks-down-what-makes-creepypasta-so-cr-237889\)](#) are the new campfire tales. They're short, scary, and read most often as urban legends. What truly distinguishes creepypasta stories, however, is that they're typically centered around technology. Video games, especially, tend to be the subject of creepypasta stories, with some tellers going so far as to create "alternate reality games" to up the spook factor and/or blur the line between truth and fiction. We've seen it before with the legendary "[BEN Drowned](#)" (http://creepypasta.wikia.com/wiki/BEN_Drowned) story (which included [its own ARG \(/https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HtpOp_get8\)](#)), and now we're seeing it unfold in real time with *Petscop*.

Kotaku first reported (<https://kotaku.com/people-are-trying-to-find-the-truth-about-a-creepy-unfi-1794538825>) on the phenomenon, which centers around a [YouTube account \(/https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCZKQv0ZFHpeIUkOtNjtq4KA\)](#) (called *Petscop*) where someone is playing through an undeveloped, unreleased Playstation game of the same name from 1997. Here's the relevant details, as provided by *Kotaku*:

The first episode, dated March 12th, sets the scene. In the footage... a guy says he wants to show off a weird game. "This is just to prove to you that I'm not lying about this game that I found," he says to an unknown recipient. As the game boots up, the title screen suggests it was created in 1997 by a studio named Garalina. (As far as I can tell, no such developer exists.)

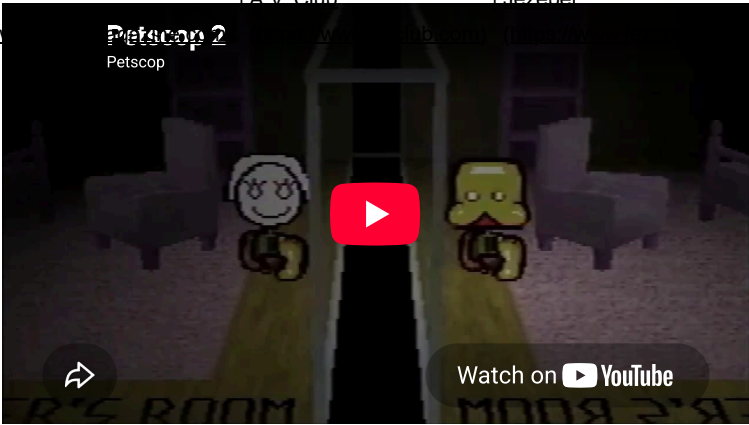
Paul takes us through the game, which he says only has one finished level—to wit, he tries walking beyond the first area, but there's nothing there. So he goes into the only available building, and he starts capturing bizarre-looking pets. You can immediately tell something is slightly off: the game warns you that the pets are scared for some mysterious reason, and that they'll run away from you. Overtly, though, *Petscop* has a very bubblegum look, full of pastel colors and boopy sound effects. There are even collectibles, something common in games of that era. So far, nothing out of the ordinary.

Soon, however, the game segues into a dark, grassy area and the peppy music gives way to silence. There's no indication where to go, so the player simply wanders.



Eventually, a mysterious door is discovered. It opens on its own and soon the player is wandering throughout a dank, subterranean lair filled with freaky notes, posters, and the graves of children. Subsequent videos give way to more and more oddities. Here's a few, as described by *Kotaku*:

There are posters with inexplicable visages. There's a grave for a kid, buildings with faces on them. At one point, he comes across a glitched-out crying child. Later, he finds a mirror room where a smiley girl mimics everything he does. In the distance, you can see the words "Quitter's Room." The room also houses a poster that asks the player if he or she remembers being born.



In one of the latest videos, the player finds an apparatus that allows you to ask it questions. After some trial and error, the player began getting some freaky responses, one of which simply reads, “Marvin picks up tool hits me when PlayStation on.” Another one implores him to turn the PlayStation off.

In the comments of each video there’s some debate as to the “authenticity” of the game. Is it really some lost relic from 1997? Probably not. But the gameplay is detailed and the graphics are lovingly designed to evoke the look of turn-of-the-millennium PlayStation games. Also, the mythology of the game seems to circle around [a little-known tragedy from 2001](http://www.nytimes.com/2001/06/19/us/therapists-are-sentenced-in-girl-s-rebirthing-death.html) (<http://www.nytimes.com/2001/06/19/us/therapists-are-sentenced-in-girl-s-rebirthing-death.html>), wherein a young girl died while being subjected to a cruel therapeutic exercise called “rebirthing.”

Real or fake, it’s creepy, fascinating stuff, the themes hearkening back to the [“Sad Satan” weirdness of 2015](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sad_Satan) (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sad_Satan). Here’s hoping this story has a better payoff than that one.

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Don't everyone try to take credit for "going Dutch" at once

The practice of splitting the check is blessed from on high.

By [Mike Vago \(/author/mike-vago\)](#) | September 20, 2026 | 11:00am

(Image: Blake Wisz/Unsplash)



We explore some of Wikipedia's oddities in our 7,238,559-part monthly series, [Wiki Wormhole](https://www.avclub.com/search?q=Wiki+Wormhole) (<https://www.avclub.com/search?q=Wiki+Wormhole>).

This week's entry: [Going Dutch](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Going_Dutch) (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Going_Dutch).

What it's about: Splitting the bill, a practice which is in fact observed in the Netherlands. But not being sure who picks up the check is a universal enough conundrum that virtually everyone on Earth has some phrase or specific tradition when the check arrives.

Biggest controversy: Much like the French exit/Irish goodbye/Peruvian repudiation, everyone tries to pin their behavior on someone else. Several Latin American countries call splitting the bill "American style"; Pakistan calls it the "American system"; Thailand says "American share." Egypt calls it "Englizy" (English style); Turks "pay the German way." A few places pin the practice to one particular city within their own country—the Portuguese say "contas à moda do Porto" (The way they do it in Porto, the second-largest city after Lisbon); Iraqis blame it on Mosul; several Middle Eastern countries say "shamia," referring to people in Damascus, who have a reputation for being stingy.

Strangest fact: Going Dutch is blessed from on high. When the check arrives in Guatemala or Honduras, people say the rhyme, "Como dijo Cristo, cada quien con su pisto," or "As Christ said, each one with their own stew." (Pisto is a ratatouille-like stew, but also slang for money in Honduras.)

Going Dutch also has roots in antiquity, as Italians "pay as the Romans do," and El Salvadorians use the rhyme, "Ley de Esparta, cada quien paga lo que se harta" ("Spartan law: each pays for what they eat"). Pretty much anything sounds badass if you preface it with "Spartan Law."

Thing we were happiest to learn: Central America isn't the only place where people have a cute phrase to say when the check comes. Nepalese say "aafno aafno" (yours, yours); in Bangladesh they use "je je, jar jar" (his his, whose whose). But our favorite is from Chile and Uruguay, where diners "hacer una vaca" (make a cow). One person collects the money for the table; unclear how the cow factors in.

Thing we were unhappiest to learn: These kids today just don't appreciate tradition. In many parts of the world, going Dutch is becoming widespread among the young, replacing older social norms. In China, the person with the most money or social standing generally was expected for the whole group; this system has broken down to the point where payment apps like WeChat and Alipay now have a "split the bill" feature built in.

Best link to elsewhere on Wikipedia: Those apps are sometimes referred to as "[super apps](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_app)" (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_app). The term was first coined to describe WeChat, which combined instant messaging and online payments, but can now include any app with multiple uses, including social media, job listings, food delivery, and the like.

[Paste](#) Elon Musk long dreamed of turning Twitter into a [Jedi](#) app that incorporated [Splinter](#) features of PayPal, the company that made him [rich](#) (<https://www.pastemagazine.com>) (<https://www.aveclub.com>) (<https://www.jendeb.com>) (<https://www.jezbe.com/splinter>) or (<https://www.pastemagazine.com>) added to X was a Nazi chatbot that [makes CSAM on demand](#) (<https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cvg1mzlrxyeo>).

Further down the Wormhole: “Going Dutch” is also catching on with the younger generation in [Afghanistan](#) (<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Afghanistan>), replacing the earlier phrase “bandar,” which means “group food.” While much of that country is mountainous desert, Afghanistan also has forests of pine, fir and [spruce](#) (<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Spruce>) trees. The latter—distinct from other conifers because of their four-sided needles—provided the wood used by the [Wright Brothers](#) (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wright_brothers) when they build the *Wright Flyer*. It was the first plane to make a controlled, sustained flight, but what next month’s column presupposes is... maybe it didn’t? We’ll look at [Gustave Whitehead](#) (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gustave_Whitehead) and his questionable claims to fame next time.

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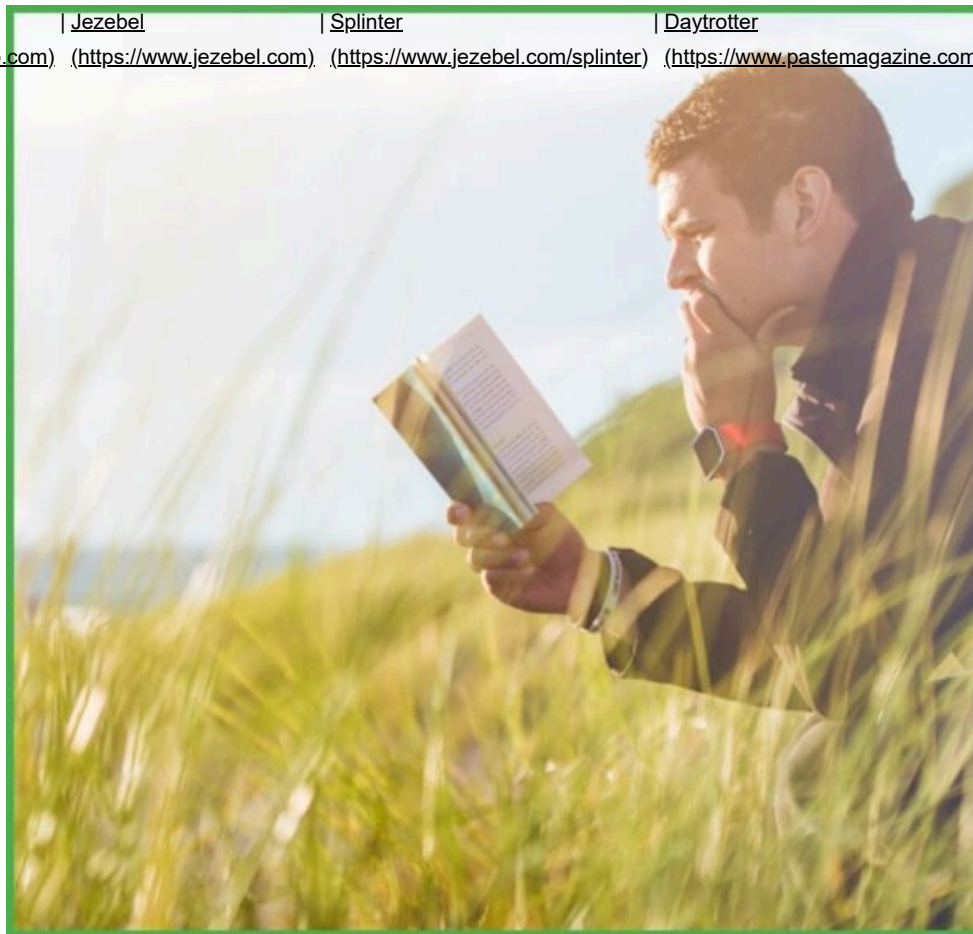
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Tech billionaires aren't juvenile science-fiction nerds, they just can't read

These oligarchs clearly need a couple of courses in the humanities.

By [Alex Cranz \(/author/alex-cranz\)](#) | September 14, 2026 | 7:00am

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Billionaires can obviously read a little. They name their companies after items from the works of J.R.R. Tolkien and design cars inspired by the ones he obviously can read. Sam Altman is a prepper with a huge collection of guns and drugs and gas masks (<https://www.newyorker.com>), writes instructions. I bet Peter Thiel, the billionaire who co-founded PayPal, mentored and funded Zuckerberg and J.D. Vance, and is the mar (<https://www.theguardian.com>), wakes up every morning and just devours financial news in between bouts of Christian apocrypha (<https://www.theguardian.com>).

In books and essays, they are usually criticized for how juvenile they are (<https://www.theatlantic.com/books/2026/08/silicon-valley-s>), lamented that (<https://variety.com/2026/tv/features/lilly-wachowski-jk-rowling-harry-potter-trans-the-matrix-1236858104/>) she “can’t read” science fiction is certainly, as Wachowski noted in the same interview, a method fascists use to co-opt and undermine messages, but then he, and the more mature Thiel and Zuckerberg, and many of the other tech billionaires who funded the latest American presidency and agenda-in-trumps-america), have zero reading comprehension skills. Which would make them functionally illiterate.

It’s a crisis already in this country (<https://abcnews.com/GMA/News/us-students-reading-scores-dive-new-data-shows/story?id=13627>), read and shows and films they watch. In the United States, we are taught that wealth equals intelligence so all these billionaires with university degrees even know engineering—Mark Zuckerberg was a great coder long before he was cutting his hair like Augustus, the Roman emperor, but

Paste (https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2018/sep/12/what-att-splinter-mark-zuckerberg-roman-hard-DaytronAugustus). Unfortunately, a (https://www.pastemagazine.com) tl (https://www.avclub.com) to (https://www.jezebel.com) an (https://www.jezebel.com/splinter) (https://www.pastemagazine.com) you how to critically engage with texts.

Zuckerberg’s mentor, Peter Thiel, did graduate and got a law degree to boot. Unfortunately he also so fundamentally misread theology Antichrist. Patheos (https://www.patheos.com/blogs/kermizarleyblog/2025/10/peter-thiel-antichrist-and-the-tech-apocalypse/?utm_source=Newsletter&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=Best+of+Patheos&utm_content=57&lctg=Tdvi&rsid=vtLb&gclid=T the non-denominational religious publication, said it was “better to ignore” Thiel’s “twisting of scripture” while the Franciscan friar w Tech oligarchy qualified him to be burned at the stake (https://legrandcontinent.eu/fr/2026/03/14/thiel-heresie-benanti/). Unlike the ol just does multiple choice tests for all grading, because Thiel cannot seem to read anything without terrible misinterpretation.

He’s one of the founders of Palantir, the all-seeing surveillance and data-aggregating SaaS (software as a service) company that works crystal balls mentioned in *The Lord Of The Rings*. Thiel chose it because he’s a nerd and his vision of Palantir was similar to that of th Tolkien’s text, the palantírs are easily corruptible and capable of profoundly dangerous misuse. They generally only lead to death and/ your big shipping concern *Titanic* because you love big ships.

Thiel was also loosely involved in the creation of another Tolkien-themed military technology company: Anduril Industries, which wa there was a market for a tech-startup-like defense contractor. They named it after the broken sword that is reforged and Aragorn carri with the goals of the company—except that Tolkien was extremely anti-war and infused the whole series with that sentiment. To read contractor. To miss that theme suggests a real failure to actually engage with and understand the text.

And that’s what we see from these billionaires again and again. Sam Altman and the other horsemen (https://arstechnica.com/culture/2 AI-pocalypse have repeatedly referenced *Star Trek* as an inspiration for the models they are training and the technology they are build each *Star Trek* series seemed to have an episode a season about the follies of technology and the dangers of handing too much power t disguised as a workers’ rights activist so the movement can be controlled by the rich. Or the entire oeuvre of Isaac Asimov, which amc

Science fiction as a genre formed partially out of a very real anxiety humans had about the rapid progress of technology. The writers v ruminations are not subtle, unless you are approaching those works with the most surface-level engagement. That’s what the tech billi playing these games and then claiming they were inspired. But they didn’t actually understand what they read, and that has nothing to

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Why de-aging is always a crapshoot

Wigs and a Snapchat filter aren't enough.

By Alex Cranz (/author/alex-cranz) | September 8, 2026 | 6:00am

Clockwise from left: Michael Douglas in Ant-Man (Photo: Marvel); Michael C. Hall (Screenshot: Dexter); Kyle Chandler (Screenshot: Lanterns); Hannah Waddingham and Octavia Spencer (Screenshot: Ride Or Die)



Kyle Chandler has aged like such fine wine that it took me a second to realize he was playing younger on HBO's *Lanterns* (<https://www.avclub.com/search?q=Lanterns>). The show hops between time periods and the actors don wigs and hair dye and occasionally a little digital makeup to make the time jumps more believable. It's surprising how well it works to have Chandler play Hal Jordan across four-plus decades. He's aged since his *Early Edition* days, but when he's playing a '90s era Hal I just see a young do-gooder in a stuffy superhero suit. I don't find myself looking for the difference and flaws in the aging technology. That's not always the case. De-aging is an art and we are all connoisseurs quite adept at recognizing the good and being appalled by the bad.

But why is the bad *so* bad? We still get lots of laughable de-aging—often in really expensive projects! I've watched *Ride Or Die* (<https://www.avclub.com/ride-or-die-review-prime-video-hannah-waddingham-octavia-spencer>) twice and delight at the costumes and the writing and performances, and cringe every time Octavia Spender and Hannah Waddingham play themselves 20 years younger, which are about as believable as Michael C. Hall as teenage Dexter the serial killer. *Dexter* became notorious for the bad wigs (<https://youtu.be/IlhbUaHdB8g?si=v9miulwTO7opB00l>) the show slapped on that man to “transform” him into a teenager, but they did not mask the fact that Hall was in his 30s. *Ride Or Die* at least took the time to airbrush away wrinkles and give both women a little youthful glow, but it still feels as cheap, as unbelievable as a *Dexter* wig.

De-aging effects are on a scale. On one end is *Dexter* and his wig: cheap, demands epic suspension of disbelief by the audience. On the far other side is the work being done by Lola VFX, which became the go-to effects house for de-aging after its work on David Fincher's *The Curious Case Of Benjamin Button*. That feels like magic. *Lanterns* and *Ride Or Die* both sit comfortably closer to the center of the de-aging scale, with *Lanterns* leaning towards magic and *Ride Or Die*...not.

The best de-aging is hard to do. Let's go ahead and stay in the superhero genre for this and use an example more recent than Benjamin Button—the *Ant-Man* franchise. Before the rushed and ultimately botched release of *Ant-Man And The Wasp: Quantumania*, the franchise was a terrific example of great effects work. Owing to flashbacks and general comic book nonsense, the *Ant-Man* movies have had to depict plenty of actors into their younger selves. I'm fairly confident Michael Douglas has had his face digitally manipulated like Play-Doh in nearly every single MCU appearance he's made. But the standout is when he had to share a scene with Hayley Atwell where he was digitally aged down and she was aged up. The scene is set in 1989 and she's got little wrinkles at the corners of her eyes and mouth and her hair (a big wig) is brushed with gray but you can't tell which lines on her face were painted on in a movie set trailer and which came later from the hands of a digital effects artist. She looks like a woman fighting the good fight for decades despite the actress being in her 30s. We know exactly what Michael Douglas looked like in 1989 and this de-aged version of him looks nearly as good as he actually did in *Wall Street*.

That was by the design of the digital effects artists of Lola VFX, which was already known at that point for *Benjamin Button* and making huge Chris Evans look like just a little guy in the first *Captain America* film. Lola artists worked closely with Marvel and Disney and coordinated everything so they could pull the scene off as believably as possible. They used both Michael Douglas and a much younger stand-in to make the character move like a 40-year old man and not a 70-year-old one. They also watched a

[Paste](https://www.pastemagazine.com/2021/07/16/ant-man-and-the-wasp-2021-2026/) lot of '80s Michael Douglas as reference. “[U]nless we work harder, [Spider-Man] the audience already knew Day-Pitt looked like (https://www.pastemagazine.com/2021/07/16/ant-man-and-the-wasp-2021-2026/).” (https://www.avclub.com/ant-man-and-the-wasp-2021-2026/). “There wasn’t a whole lot of leeway.”

Using those references, they added fat back to his cheeks. They shrank his ears and nose. Shifted the muscles in his face, removed blood visible vessels and added a youthful glow to his skin. They even gave him a digital neck left—pulling skin on his neck back to where it would have more likely resided in 1989. Claus speaks of the work the same way a sculptor might. “What’s really important is the way his face moves as he speaks, the way that the muscles in the face have changed over time, the way the skin reacts to those muscles,” he told Vulture. “To sell the effect you have to look at the way [the face] looks in motion.” The work Claus and Lola VFX did is good enough it holds up more than 10 years later. Then they came back and did it again to Michelle Pfeiffer in *Ant-Man And The Wasp*, and the results looked just as good, proving that a whole crew of very skilled artists can make older actors look young again with just a lot of time and Disney/Marvel money.

It’s not a surprise that *Ride Or Die* and *Lanterns* didn’t go this route. Lola-level VFX are expensive and time-consuming, and if you run out of either time or money you will be left with a boondoggle like *Ant-Man And The Wasp: Quantumania*, where Marvel went the much cheaper route of blurring some wrinkles and slapping on some wigs. We basically all did the same on Zoom calls during the pandemic. I did not have to touch my makeup once from April 2020 to my first office visit in the summer of 2021 because Zoom could blur away all blemishes and even give me some healthy color. The technology is effectively the same and is seen in every filter you use on Snapchat, TikTok, or Instagram. A simple algorithm makes digital tracking points on the face and applies a digital mask onto those points. It’s not perfect, but it’s good enough.

Except it really isn’t when you’re watching a TV show that cost millions of dollars to produce. The makers of *Lanterns* seem to understand this. And thus far the younger Kyle Chandler has had to look, the darker and blurrier the scene. We see young Hal Jordan on a fuzzy TV screen and on moodily lit sets. When we do see a younger Hal in the sunlight, he’s also only meant to be a decade younger than the one in the 2016 timeline. The wigs and Snapchat filter effect work just fine in that context.

The problem with *Ride Or Die* and so many other bad examples of de-aging, like whatever they did to Winona Ryder in the *Stranger Things* season five flashbacks, is not understanding the limitations of the technology. In episode two of *Ride Or Die*, there’s a whole lovely scene of the two leads as twentysomething women bonding that’s all tight closeups in a well-lit car, but it’s very clearly two older women in wigs. It’s almost as comical as watching a 31-year-old Maya Erskine in a mushroom hair wig [bitch out a 13-year-old boy](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=g41_wpc_8r0) (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=g41_wpc_8r0) in *Pen15*, which starred Erskine and Anna Konkle as 13-year-old girls. But that was part of the joke in *Pen15*. It’s in *Ride Or Die*. It takes real technique to pull off digital de-aging. The crapshoot happens when filmmakers or TV creators think a wig and a blur filter are enough.

The point of these de-aging effects is that they’re supposed to be special. You are meant to wonder how they pulled it off, or not even notice the effects were there. Wigs and a filter that’s two steps above a Snapchat one are just normal tools in the toolbox of any filmmaker in 2026. There is no marvel in them in this day and age. There’s only a crapshoot.

Alex Cranz writes about the intersection between pop culture and technology.

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Recommended for You

- 1 Brad Pitt is actually kinda famous in *The Further Mis-Adventures Of Cliff Booth* trailer (https://www.avclub.com/further-mis-adventures-of-cliff-booth-trailer-netflix-brad-pitt)
- 2 CNN, MS NOW, *Politico* sue White House over lack of press access (https://www.avclub.com/cnn-ms-now-politico-sue-white-house)
- 3 It's finally safe for Jessica Chastain's *The Savant* to hunt hate groups again (https://www.avclub.com/the-savant-apple-tv-jessica-chastain-finally-coming-out)
- 4 *My Brother's Wedding*, an early classic from a Black cinema pioneer, gets a second life (https://www.avclub.com/my-brothers-wedding-4k-restoration-charles-burnett-interview)
- 5 AVQ&A: What's your most anticipated fall TV premiere? (https://www.avclub.com/most-anticipated-fall-tv-premieres-dig-carrie-black-doves)

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